BETTER PROMPTS IN 5 STEPS

A practical job aid for non-technical teams using generative AI

Representative portfolio artifact - created to demonstrate performance-support and AI-enablement design.

1. STATE THE OUTCOME

Start with what "good" looks like. Ask for an observable result, not just a topic.

EXAMPLE Weak: "Help with this report."
Better: "Turn these notes into a one-page executive summary with three decisions and two risks."

2. GIVE USEFUL CONTEXT

Provide the audience, situation, constraints, source material, and what the model should not assume.

EXAMPLE "The audience is a non-technical VP. Use only the information below. Flag anything that needs verification."

3. DEFINE THE FORMAT

Specify the structure, length, tone, and level of detail you need.

EXAMPLE "Use a short opening paragraph, then a 3-column table: Issue | Evidence | Recommended action."

4. SET QUALITY RULES

Tell the model how to handle uncertainty, sources, privacy, and review.

EXAMPLE "Do not invent missing facts. Mark uncertain claims. Do not include confidential data in examples."

5. ITERATE WITH EVIDENCE

Review the output against the goal. Revise the prompt based on what failed—not just what you disliked.

EXAMPLE "The analysis is accurate, but too technical. Rewrite at an 8th-grade reading level and keep the same conclusions."

Quick quality check

- Is the requested outcome clear?
- Did I give enough context without exposing sensitive data?
- Did I specify the format and audience?
- Did I tell the model what not to invent?
- Did I verify important facts before using the output?

HUMAN-IN-THE-LOOP RULE Use AI to accelerate thinking and drafting. Keep human judgment responsible for accuracy, appropriateness, privacy, and final decisions.